

Comments on Reconstructions of Ballet Classics

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A prominent question in the philosophy of music, is the ontological nature of a given musical work. The question of the ontological nature of a musical work has since begun to present complications for other related Western musical traditions which prominently feature musical “things”. These can especially include ballet “performances”. An important question there then highlights the relation between a musical work and what that relation has to do with a given ballet performance as a work. A standard here is that often times, the authenticity of a musical work relies on compliance with a score ([Kania 2024](#)). However, it is not clear whether the authenticity of a ballet performance also relies solely on compliance with its musical score, since the choreography is amenable to change without effecting our understanding of the authenticity of the performance.

Professor Julie Van Camp then asks what factors in 19th century ballet reconstructions and reenactments help us to determine whether a given dance is authentic, accurate, or neither. One possibility is requiring the same sets of standards that would be employed when considering a historical item for display in a museum. One helpful heuristic of the contrast between reenactment and reconstruction then, is the focus on demonstrating how a dance might be redone vs. a phenomenological way of understanding “what it was *like to do it*” ([Franko 2017, 1](#)). One helpful label of this work then would be to focus on the authenticity of a given performance either as being compliant with a score, or compliance with the original meaning of the work.

Using the definition offered by Mark Franko ([2017](#)) in his introduction to the Oxford handbook of dance and reenactment, reconstructions are preservations of past accomplishments while it is not yet clear whether reenactments aim to reimagine those past performances instead, or whether these have some additional aim. On this later point, it would appear that there are many important reasons for re-imagining a ballet performance. For one, if we do not have an authentic historical item from a particular time period to include in a museum collection from that time period, it may make sense to use the nearest counterpart. Analogously, considering the 19th century ballet performances *Swan Lake*, *Giselle* and *The Sleeping Beauty*, these exist though we do not have relevant dance notations of their original performances. Therefore it would be an important project to determine what the nearest counterpart might be since there are at least two different ways to understand the term “nearest counterpart”. One important direction of consideration here, is that an important part of the essence of a performance, apart from its compliance with either a music or dance score would be the emotional essence of a given performance. Lukacs ([1977](#)) argues that a work’s emotional essence is produced by social factors. But these do not seem to be factors that can be displayed in a museum in the traditional sense. Perhaps the closest terms we have for this distinction in the reenactment and reconstruction literature, is what Andrew Kania ([2024](#)) attributes to Julian Dodd ([2020](#)); ‘compliance’ authenticity versus ‘*interpretive*’ authenticity.

First, Professor Van Camp carefully and expertly draws out the complications for understanding why this is a hard problem. In three prominent examples of the reconstructions of the 19th century pieces, ***Swan Lake***, ***Giselle***, and ***Sleeping Beauty***, if we focus on audience reactions to these pieces, then the ‘reconstructions’ do not appear to have been as appealing as their 19th century reenactment counterparts since audience favor typically follows works that reimagine classics. This later position is explored with more detail in a review written by Professor Van Camp explaining the loose requirements for authenticity in ballet reenactments versus those of reconstructions,

usually focus on a shift of social values. Tamara Rojo as the artistic director for the San Francisco Ballet delicately introduces variations in her version of *Raymonda* by “expunging Middle Eastern stereotypes” and exploring new forms of agency by introducing a female heroine rather than a male hero. This shows the tolerance ballet has for variation without loss of ontological identity. But this may also just mean that a work’s ontological identity is grounded somewhere else.

Professor Van Camp defends these loose standards as authentically derivative since often times our own standards are amenable to change in other areas, such as values which we know have strong emotive force. A central question here then could be the shifting plasticity of standards and how these diverge between reconstructions and reenactments. This is especially important if we consider whether there is a more ultimate and underlying truth at which multiple performances of a work may attempt to reveal. At the Paris 1913 premier of *Le Sacre du Printemps* staged by Vaslav Nijinsky, it is said that the audience rioted owing to the near primal movements of the performers. In 2009, the resident choreographer for the Boston Ballet premiered a version of *Le Sacre du Printemps* that diverged from Nijinsky’s “uncontrolled and raw movements” with the introduction of “clean shapes, intricate isolations, and dynamic partner work”. Elo defends his interpretation arguing that highlighting the performances universal value of “community, identity, and social systems” did not require the “sacrifice for the common good” that it required when Nijinsky staged the work in 1913. This is important considering the role the performance played in moving the theater into the modern era of ballet.

But this also leads to an additional question, how audiences think of these 19th century reconstructions as authentic and historically accurate and why and what this means for our accepted notions of authenticity and accuracy. Perhaps it is not necessary here to make any comment on what is considered an audience. Some audiences desire to ‘view the past accomplishments of dance’ and others are more interested in imagining what a historical performance would look like when adding the benefit of ‘improved diet, health, and training regimes’ of the modern period. As noted by Julian Dodd (2020) in his *Being True to Works of Music*, it is possible that the distinction here then, is one between ‘compliance’ authenticity and ‘interpretive’ authenticity. For instance, it is not clear whether Professor Van Camp follows Andrew Kania (2024) in equating ‘authenticity’ with ‘genuineness’ so that an ‘authentic’ performance is a mere ‘genuine’ interpretation of a score, and more importantly what this has to do with the compliance and interpretation distinction. However, one plausible direction in which this discussion could move, is through a focus on interpretive authenticity.

The biggest complication here is that taking the understanding of producing a ‘genuine’ work means producing an ‘authorized’ score for that work. But this is not all that determines the authenticity of a work. There are many considerations that go into producing an ‘authorized’ score. Lukacs (1977) would argue that these considerations include the underlying values the score seeks to express. Professor Van Camp considers *Swan Lake*, *The Sleeping Beauty*, and *Giselle* since there are instances of these works that were created without a choreographic notational system. The inclusion of the notational system in order to be authorized then, needs to account of fidelity to some expressed value. Therefore, this fact will have us question the conditions for understanding a work rely solely on the *musical* notation ascribed to a ballet performance and not specific features of the dance itself. Therefore there are at least two different standards for a work’s authenticity.

So while it is not clear what the standards are for a work being authentic, Professor Van Camp may accept the ballet reconstruction as authentic simply if it complies with the musical score. But using the 1913 performance of *Le Sacre du Printemps* in Paris staged by Nijinsky and the 2009 version staged by Elo, another important question emerges. Here, maybe there are underlying values which a work intends to portray and we can either expect riots

when a performance fails to express them adequately, or acclaim when they succeed. With ballet, which can contain both musical and choreographic scores, it would seem that there are additional factors one may consider when attempting to determine authenticity besides fidelity to a performances musical, or dance score. So even if we only consider the musical score for a historic ballet performance, there are still multiple types of authenticity we can rely on and what the scores these are is not clear.

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